

Syria: Pentagon denies reports that US troops have evacuated some bases



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A Department of Defense spokesperson told Sputnik that reports that US troops are leaving some of their military posts in Syria are untrue, adding that the military's mission in that country has not changed.

Iran's Al-Alam news agency reported, citing a military source, that US forces have evacuated three bases inside Syria, including a post near the al-Omar oil field in Deir Ez-Zor province.

"That's not true. Our mission in Syria remains unchanged," a Defense Department spokesperson said Thursday. "We checked this morning to confirm."

The United States and its allies have been conducting a ground military operation in war-torn Syria since 2014, supporting rebels and anti-Assad Syrian forces.

Syrian authorities have repeatedly stressed that the government has never granted the US permission to conduct any operations on its territory and considers the US military presence an illegal occupation, accompanied by the plundering of natural resources belonging to the country's population.

Since 2015, the US command has established nine military bases in eastern and northeastern Syria. Four of these are located near the Deir ez-Zor oil fields, and five more in the neighboring province of Al-Hasakah, widely considered Syria's breadbasket.

In total, the Pentagon estimates its presence in the country at approximately 900 troops.

In late 2019, then-US President Donald Trump approved a plan under which several hundred US troops would remain in the Middle Eastern nation, and one of their main tasks would be specifically to secure control over oil fields in the northeast and east.